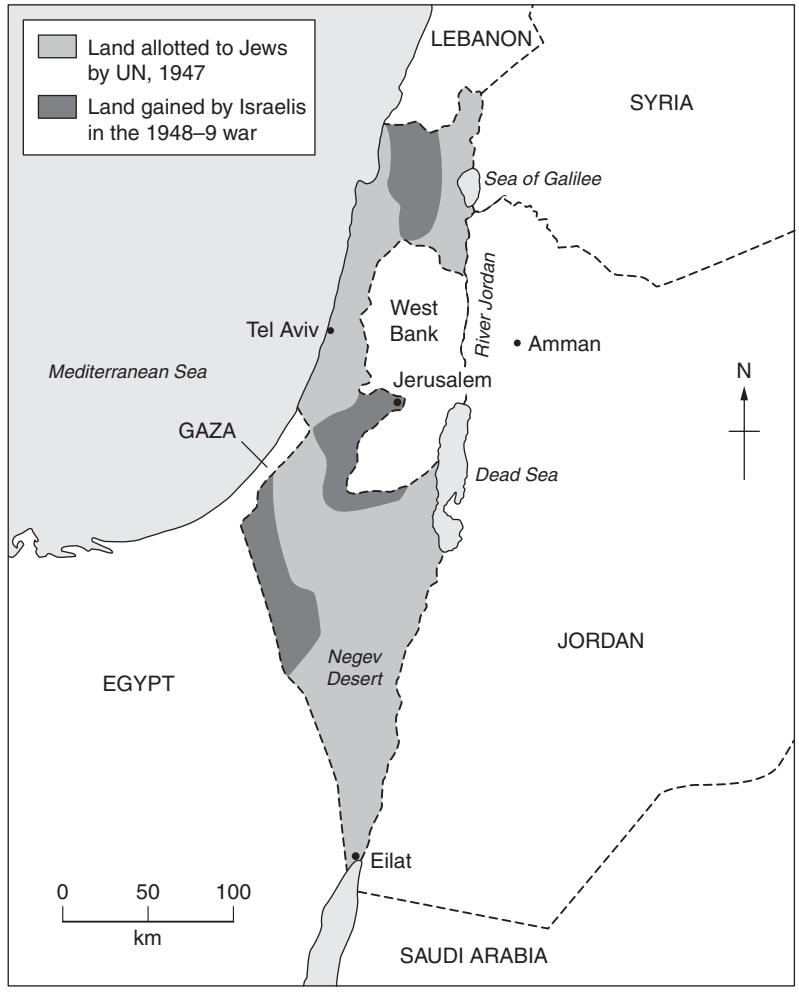
Israeli gains in the 1948–9 war.



700,000 Palestinian Arabs had become refugees, having fled or been driven from their homes. Most ended up in Gaza or what became known as the West Bank (see the map above). This flight, and the events of 1947–49 as a whole, have become known in Arabic as the '***Nakbah***', the catastrophe or disaster.

Key term

Nakbah
An Arabic word for 'catastrophe' or 'disaster', used to refer to the 1948–9 war and the creation of the Palestinian refugee problem.

For the Israelis, this had been the war of national liberation. They had survived their first great test and were confident of their future as an independent nation. An American Zionist, Nahum Goldmann, wrote of the psychological effects of the Israeli victory:

> It seemed to show the advantages of direct action over negotiation and diplomacy. … The victory offered such a glorious contrast to the centuries of persecution and humiliation, of adaptation and compromise, that it seemed to indicate the only direction that could possibly be taken from then on. To tolerate no attack … and shape history by creating facts so simple, so compelling, so satisfying that it became Israel's policy in its conflict with the Arab world.